

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

TUESDAY, JANUARY 6, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Aldermen's historic budget now reality

But version may not be finished product

By Jake Sheridan and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

For decades, strong Chicago mayors told acquiescent aldermen here's the budget, take it or leave it, secure in the knowledge they had the votes to pass basically whatever they wanted.

The message has long been "trust me, it's great," Ald. Nicole Lee said.

But the City Council gave a new reply this year when Mayor Brandon Johnson put forward his plan, "Locking arms and jumping off the edge together," Lee said.

Where they landed is now Chicago history: The council majority wrested power from the mayor to close the budget gap with a final batch of new spending, cuts and taxes of its own design.

That revolt locked in critical changes to city policy, many made with little public discussion. The new version largely replaced Johnson's plans to install a corporate head tax and halve a planned advanced pension payment.

Aldermen legalized video gambling machines in neighborhood establishments, restructured liquor taxes to bring in more revenue, cleared the way for advertising on downtown bridges and more.

The quick, dramatic shift has left many questions unanswered. Top among them: Did aldermen pass a budget that is truly more sustainable or only more politically palatable?

Just before the Christmas holiday, Johnson opted against a veto but cried foul.

"They stuck something in the budget within a week and then asked people to vote on it," Johnson said. "The people of this city did not get a full chance to get a full read on what was being proposed."

The projections aldermen made for their policy changes are often bold, but not necessarily implausible, civic analysts told the Tribune. And while the winning counterproposal makes some key changes favorable to credit rating agencies, it also clings to entrenched practices that continue to make

Turn to Budget, Page 5



Nicolás Maduro, the ousted president of Venezuela, and his wife, Cilia Flores, are escorted off a helicopter en route to the federal courthouse in Manhattan on Monday morning. VINCENT ALBAN/THE NEW YORK TIMES

'I was captured,' Maduro tells court

Venezuelan declares himself president, pleads not guilty

By Michael R. Sisak, Larry Neumeister and Eric Tucker
Associated Press

NEW YORK — A defiant Nicolás Maduro declared himself "the president of my country" as he protested his capture and pleaded not guilty Monday to the federal drug trafficking charges that the Trump administration used to justify removing him from power in Venezuela.

"I was captured," Maduro said in Spanish as translated by a courtroom reporter before being cut off by the judge. Asked later for his plea to the charges, he stated: "I'm innocent. I am not guilty. I am a decent man, the president of my country."

The courtroom appearance, Maduro's first since he and his wife were seized from their home in a middle-of-the-night mili-

tary operation, kicks off the U.S. government's most consequential prosecution in decades of a foreign head of state. The criminal case in Manhattan is unfolding against a broader diplomatic backdrop of an audacious U.S.-engineered regime change that President Donald Trump has said will enable his administration to "run" the South American country.

Maduro was led into court along with his co-defendant wife just before noon for the brief legal proceeding. Both put on headsets to hear the English-language proceeding as it was translated into Spanish.

The couple traveled to the Manhattan courthouse under armed guard early Monday from the Brooklyn jail where they've been detained since they were transported to the

Turn to Maduro, Page 9

MORE COVERAGE INSIDE

■ U.S. Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi said he planned to introduce legislation in Washington that would block federal funds from being used for U.S. military occupation in Venezuela. **Page 4**

■ Shares of major U.S. companies in the energy sector were sharply higher after President Donald Trump announced plans to take control of Venezuela's oil industry and said American companies would revitalize it. **Business**

■ The Venezuelan government sought to show its people and the world that the country is being run independently and not controlled by the United States. **Nation & World**

■ Both allies and adversaries of the United States used an emergency meeting of the U.N. Security Council to voice opposition to the military operation in Venezuela. **Nation & World**



Lead medical assistant Yiseli Dominguez administers a flu vaccine to a patient at the Esperanza Health Centers Brighton Park North Clinic on Dec. 31. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Feds' decision will have 'no bearing' on Illinois vaccine guidance, health official says

'Very high' levels of flu activity reached, state announces Monday

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

The federal government's decision to dramatically reduce the number of vaccines it recommends for children, including the flu shot, will have "no bearing" on Illinois' vaccine recommendations, said the director of the Illinois Department of Public Health on Monday — the same day that Illinois announced that the state had moved to "very high" levels of flu activity.

The head of the federal Centers for Disease Control and Prevention on Monday formally moved to

remake the childhood vaccination schedule, to recommend children be vaccinated against 10 illnesses, whereas it previously recommended 17 immunizations for all children.

Federal health care leaders said the new vaccine schedule came after a review of other countries' vaccine practices and the scientific evidence behind them, conducted at the instruction of President Donald Trump.

"After an exhaustive review of the evidence, we are aligning the U.S. childhood vaccine schedule with international consensus while strengthening transparency and informed consent," said Robert F. Kennedy Jr., secretary of the U.S. Department of Health and Human

Turn to Vaccine, Page 2

Caribbean travel resumes after disruption from Venezuela action

Key airlines announced Caribbean air travel has returned to normal after hundreds of flights were disrupted this weekend by the U.S. military operation that captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro on Saturday. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

State/Lake 'L' station in Loop closes; won't open again until 2029

The station is slated to get demolished and rebuilt as part of a \$444 million revamp the CTA and the Chicago Department of Transportation say will "improve safety, accessibility, and comfort for all riders." **Business**

Sen. Kelly vows to fight censure from Hegseth over troop video

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth announced that he censured Democratic Sen. Mark Kelly of Arizona over the former Navy pilot's participation in a video that called on troops to resist unlawful orders. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 43 Low 37

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 6 © Chicago Tribune

